

Advertisement

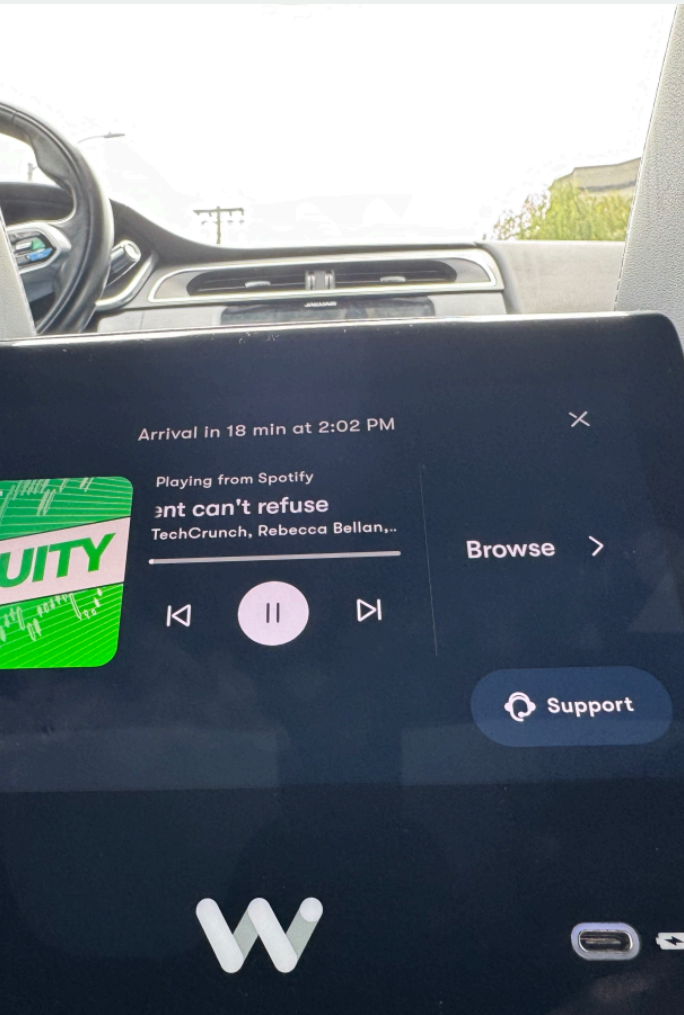


IMAGE CREDITS: MAXWELL ZEFF

TRANSPORTATION

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [r](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Waymo finally has a music experience worthy of its robotaxi

Maxwell Zeff — 1:03 PM PDT · August 13, 2025

I'm riding in the back of a Waymo that's autonomously navigating the busy streets of San Francisco with relative ease thanks to 29 external cameras, six radar, and five lidar sensors all feeding into an AI model. For just 15 bucks, I get to experience what feels like a miracle of modern technology, and yet, there's a nagging thought I can't shake.

The music sucks in here.

Waymo's music-streaming feature has felt like an aged barnacle attached to a futuristic shell. Until this week, passengers were limited to a few music stations that played lo-fi beats, smooth jazz, K-pop, or other genres they may or may not care for. For those who wanted to listen to something more specific, they had to use another app from Waymo's parent company Alphabet.

For iPhone users, that meant downloading the Google Assistant app and configuring it to connect to Spotify. At that point, you had to ask Google Assistant through written or verbal commands to stream certain songs, artists, or playlists on the Waymo. Even if you get to this point — at which you may be halfway to your destination and have listened to approximately three lo-fi beats — the service didn't work reliably.

As I rode along in a robotaxi full of cutting-edge technology, I was puzzled why Waymo had not figured out a simple way to stream music from my phone into the car's speakers — a breakthrough that automakers and audio manufacturers figured out a couple of decades ago.

That's why I was pleasantly surprised this week to see that Waymo launched a [Spotify integration](#) allowing users to seamlessly link the music-streaming and robotaxi-hailing services. I immediately connected the services and hailed a Waymo to see how it would work.

TEC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

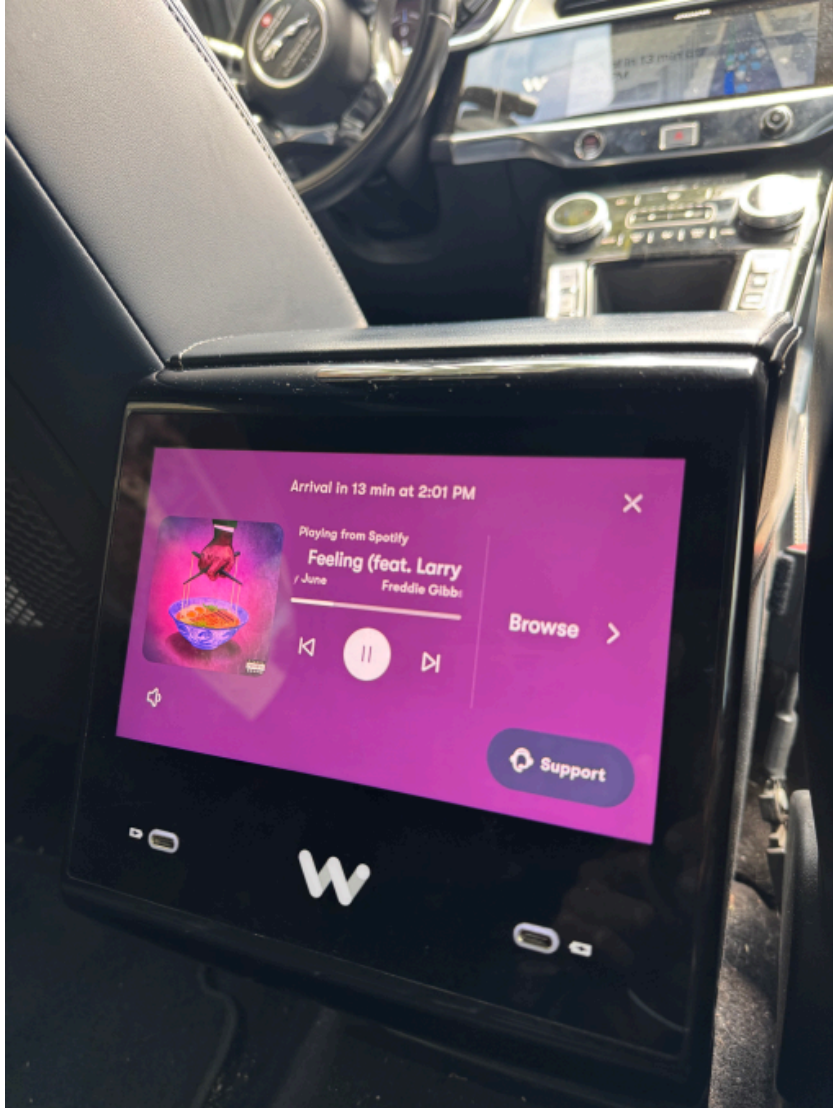
Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- [HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach](#)
- [How your solar rooftop became a national security issue](#)
- [A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs](#)
- [Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company](#)
- [Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request](#)
- [NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars](#)
- [Why I finally left Spotify](#)



LISTENING TO SPOTIFY IN A WAYMO.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

Waymo's Spotify integration is nothing groundbreaking, but it adds to the user experience. It works seamlessly, which is roughly what I would expect when trying to play music on my car's speakers in 2025. But riding around in a Waymo, listening to my own playlist or picking up where I left off on a podcast, the back seat of the robotaxi feels more like my own space — which is increasingly the reason I opt for a Waymo.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

To set it up, open the Waymo app and navigate to the "Music" section, where you will notice a new offering that lets you connect to Spotify. From

there, you can press a button and authorize Spotify to connect to Waymo, albeit while giving the robotaxi provider some access to your listening information.

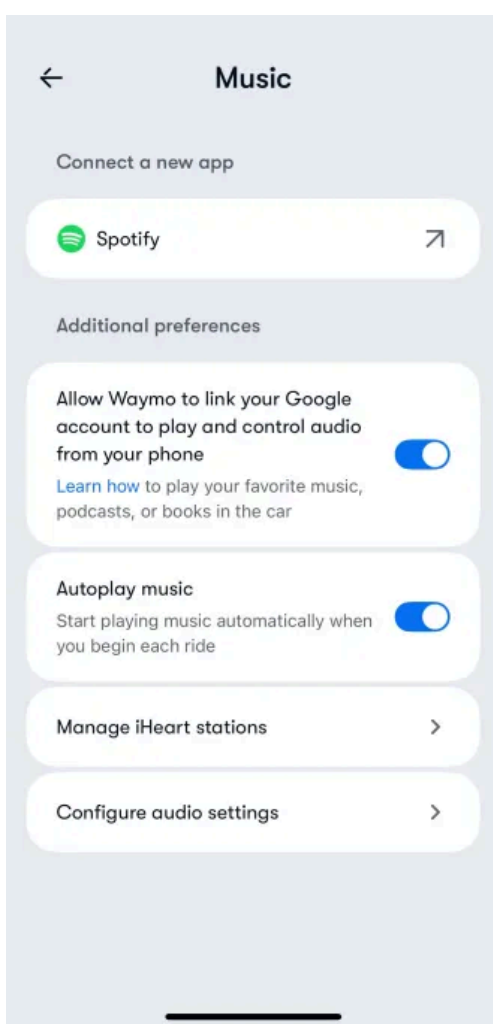


IMAGE CREDITS: MAXWELL ZEFF
(SCREENSHOT)

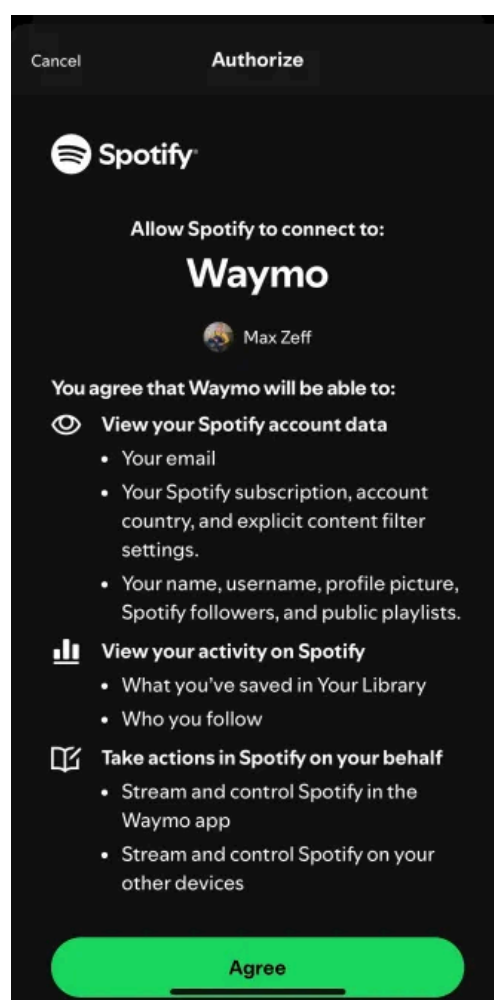


IMAGE CREDITS: MAXWELL ZEFF
(SCREENSHOT)

I'm sure Apple Music users will soon want to stream their music and podcasts in Waymos as well. Waymo spokesperson Chris Bonelli told TechCrunch the company is always exploring new personalization options but did not clarify when the company might add an Apple Music integration.

Once my Waymo and Spotify accounts were linked, I hailed a Waymo like I usually would and got in. On the Waymo's touchscreen in the back seat, there's an option to select Spotify. I tapped it, and the podcast I was listening to on my headphones started playing from the exact spot I left off.

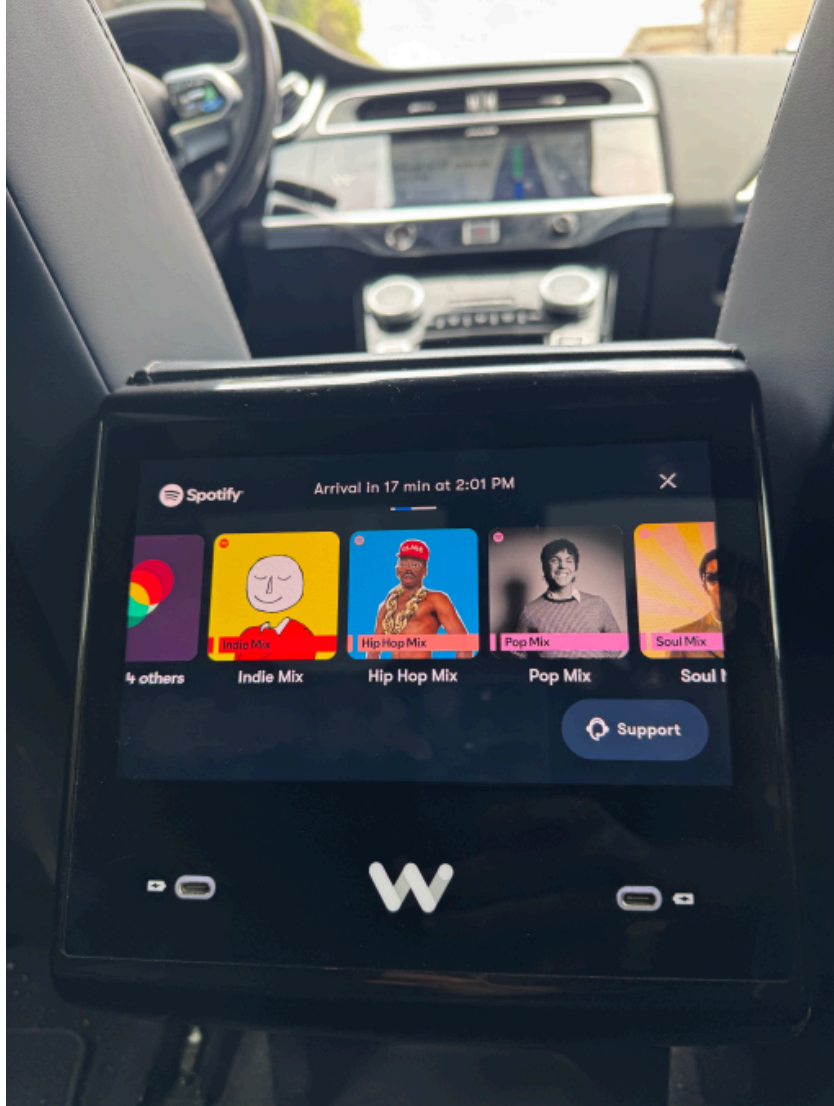


LISTENING TO TECHCRUNCH'S FLAGSHIP PODCAST IN A WAYMO.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

You can turn “autoplay” on or off in Waymo’s Music settings, and upon entry, the robotaxi will automatically start playing whatever song or podcast you were listening to on Spotify. I liked having it on, but it does feel like it could get you into an odd situation if you’re listening to an intense true crime podcast and then get into a Waymo with work colleagues.

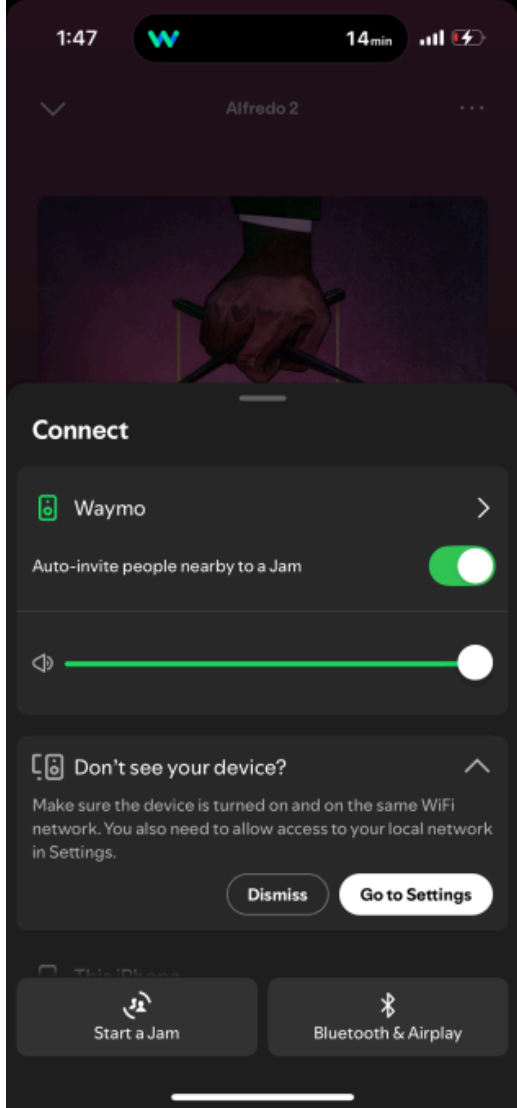
You can also use the Waymo’s touchscreen to select from a variety of customized playlists that Spotify users will be familiar with, such as your “Daylist” or other mixes. However, this selection doesn’t seem to include albums, audiobooks, or podcasts that you’ve recently listened to.



CHOOSING FROM DIFFERENT SPOTIFY MIXES.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

Luckily, your Spotify app now controls the music in the Waymo. You can simply select any song or playlist you want from your smartphone and stream it throughout the vehicle like you would using Apple CarPlay or a bluetooth speaker.



CONTROLLING THE WAYMO'S TUNES WITH YOUR PHONE. IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

In the end, the Spotify integration made my robotaxi feel more personalized; I was even able to tweak the bass, subwoofer, and treble levels in the car’s speakers. That personalization may not be the main attraction for first-time users, but it could keep them coming back — and a loyal customer base is exactly what Waymo needs.

Topics: [AI](#) [robotaxi](#) [Spotify](#) [Transportation](#) [Waymo](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [👍](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Maxwell Zeff
Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg, and MSNBC, Zeff has covered the rise of AI and the Silicon...

[View Bio](#) >

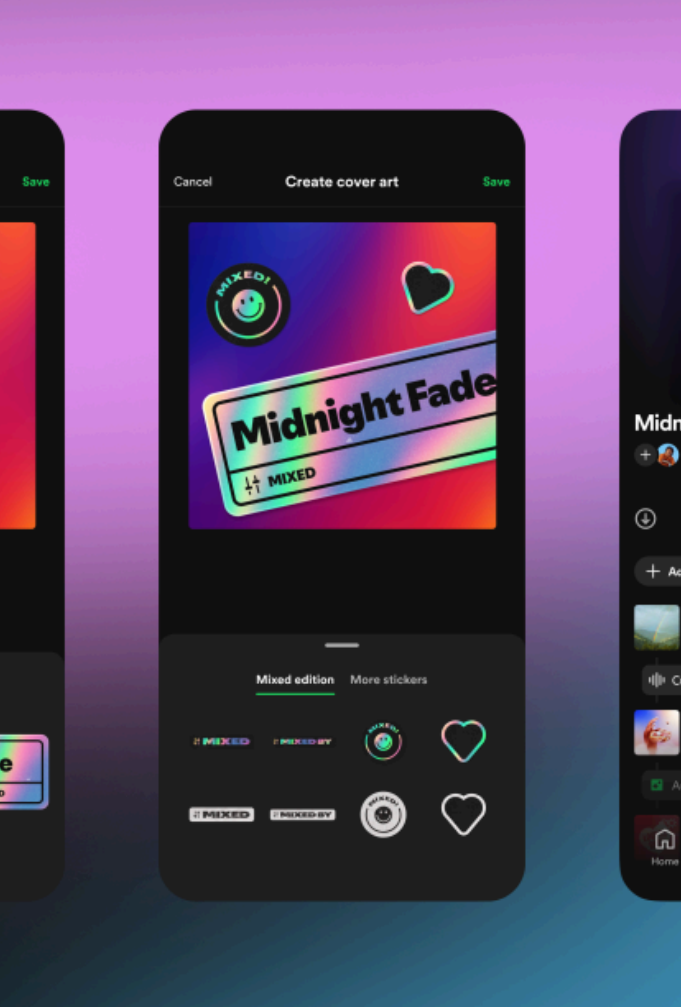


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

APPS



Spotify's latest feature lets you add your own transitions to playlists

Sarah Perez — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Spotify is [introducing](#) a new feature that allows subscribers to create more professional, personalized playlists. On Tuesday, the company launched a custom transitions feature that lets you either automatically add transitions between a playlist's tracks or customize your own using preset options like fade, rise, or blend, along with other options.

To use the feature, open any playlist and select "Mix" from the toolbar to begin editing. While customizing the track with different transition styles, you can also adjust settings for things like the volume, EQ, and effects, and use the waveform and beat data to find the best spot in each track to begin the transition.

Spotify notes that it will automatically display the key and the beats per minute for each track, to make it easier for novice audio mixers to get started.

Advertisement

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News

Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.



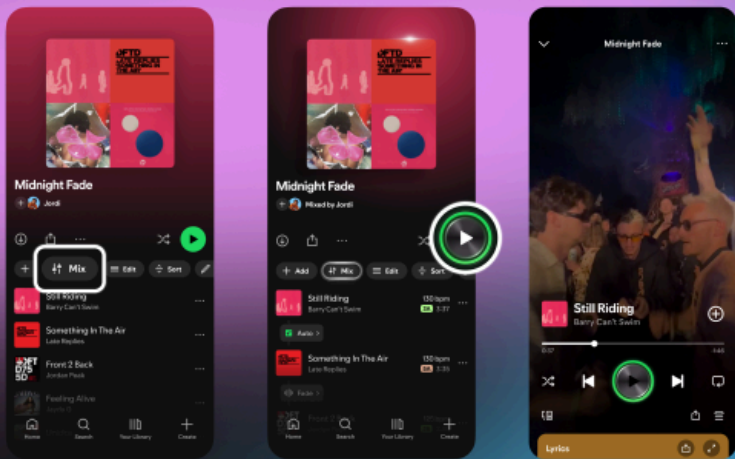


IMAGE CREDITS:SPOTIFY

The new options are designed to appeal to playlist experts and other music fans, who have collectively created nearly 9 billion playlists on Spotify’s platform to date.

The rollout complements other updates Spotify has launched over the past year that give users more control over their listening experience, the company says, like the tools to [add, sort, and edit playlists](#), [customize the genre of the Discover Weekly](#) playlist, [snooze tracks](#), [make voice requests to the AI DJ](#), and more. It also allows Spotify to compete with Apple Music’s [upcoming](#) AutoMix feature, which is currently live in the iOS 26 developer beta, and claims to let you mix “like a DJ.”

Premium subscribers with access to the transitions feature will also be able to save and share the playlist with other friends on social media or even invite other subscribers to collaborate on a mixed playlist.

The mix can be toggled on and off at any time by pressing the “mix” option, allowing you to turn your playlist back to the more traditional kind when the party or gym workout (or wherever else you’re streaming the mix) has ended.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Startups Weekly

Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review

Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility

TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).

Advertisement



IMAGE CREDITS:SPOTIFY

The company recommends that mixing works best with music that’s already been produced for seamless transitions, like house and techno, which tend to blend more easily.

Like other playlists, the mixes can be further [customized using your own cover art](#) along with newly added stickers and labels made just for mixed playlists.

Custom transitions in playlists are available starting today for the majority of eligible Premium users worldwide. (The company says some markets in the APAC region will still need to wait for the addition.) The feature is rolling out gradually to users who have updated their Spotify app for iOS or Android.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [Music](#) [Spotify](#) [streaming](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at ReadWriteWeb. Prior to h...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

Set your alarms. Bookmark this page. Refresh like your future depends on it.

IMAGE CREDITS: [FLICKR](#)

After reviewing thousands of groundbreaking applications from around the globe, TechCrunch is just days away from announcing the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 — our handpicked cohort of the most promising early-stage startups set to take the stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) this October 27-29.

The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list will go live, right here, on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT.

Whether you applied, referred a standout founder, or just want to see who made the cut, this is the moment you’ve been waiting for. Your name. Your rival. Your next investment. They might all be on this list.

This October marks 20 years that [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) has been shaping the startup world — and we’re pulling out all the stops. For two decades, the biggest names in tech, venture capital, and startups have taken our stage to share their visions and make history. Game-changers like Dropbox, Cloudflare, Fitbit, and Discord got their start in [Startup Battlefield](#) — and this is where the next generation of breakout companies will be born.

Want to see these rising stars pitch live? Hear from top-tier founders and investors? Network with the people shaping the future of tech? [Grab your ticket to Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 in San Francisco.

Last year’s winner, [Salva Health](#), topped a competitive field of startups with its development of a portable device to detect breast cancer early,

Latest in Startups

[See More](#)

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

STARTUPS

AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27

Isabelle Johannessen
- 23 hours ago

especially in rural populations that lack access to mammograms and other diagnostic tools. You can relive their victory below, [listen to our Equity podcast interview with CEO Valentina Agudelo](#), or [get a detailed rundown of their journey here](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Announcing the winner of Startup Battlefield 200 | TechCrunch Disr...



Salva was far from alone. Out of the cohort of 200 trailblazing startups, TechCrunch editorial selected the [2024 Top 20 finalists](#) who wowed the crowd with their disruptive innovations, live demos, and perfected pitches. Runner-up [geCKo Materials turned heads with its compelling story](#) about how years of research led to a breakthrough innovation in adhesive materials that is disrupting the Velcro industry one impossibly sticky situation at a time.

This year's Startup Battlefield 200 Top 20 finalists will be revealed on Day 1 of Disrupt 2025 (Monday, October 27). You don't want to miss the chance to see these founders battle it out live onstage for the \$100,000 prize and Disrupt Cup. Your incumbent will be there. Your competitors have registered. Don't get left behind — [get your tickets to Disrupt 2025](#).

Mark your calendars and set your alarms — the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops right here on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT. Be the first to see which exceptional startups made the cut.

Startup Battlefield is proudly presented by Google Cloud, our premier sponsor.



We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [Gecko Materials](#) [Salva Health](#) [Startup Battlefield](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#)

[TechCrunch Disrupt](#) [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#)



Isabelle Johannessen

Startup Battlefield Program Manager

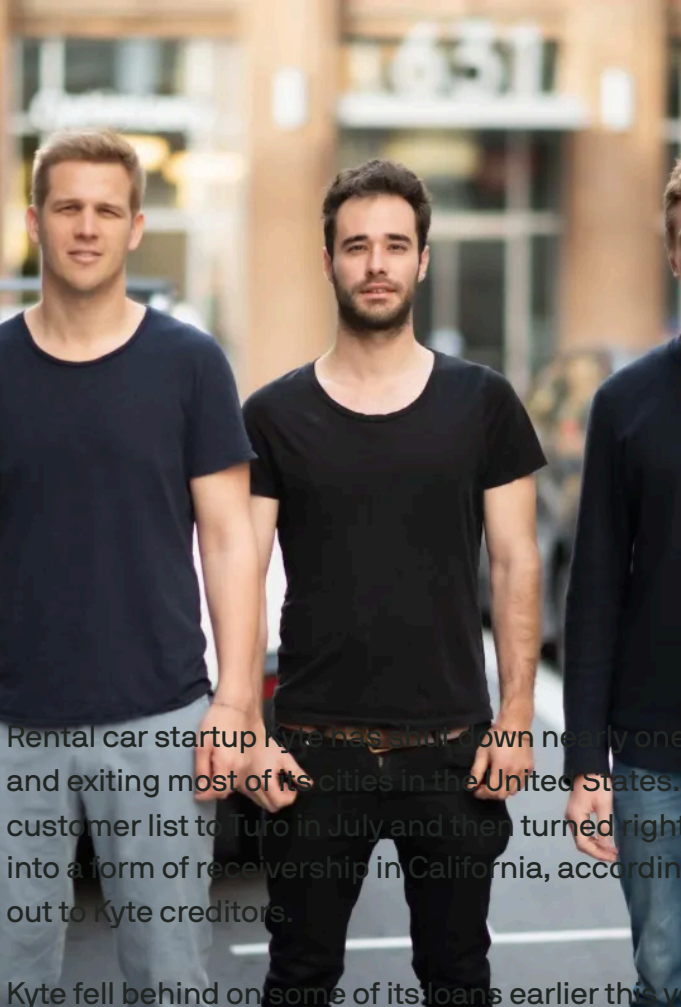
Isabelle leads Startup Battlefield, TechCrunch's iconic launchpad and competition for the world's most promising early-stage startups....

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

TRANSPORTATION





Kyte, which billed itself as the ‘best competitor to Hertz,’ shuts down

Sean O'Kane — 11:29 AM PDT · August 15, 2025

Rental car startup Kyte has shut down nearly one year [after slashing staff](#) and exiting most of its cities in the United States. The company sold its customer list to Turo in July and then turned right around and entered into a form of receivership in California, according to a [notice](#) that went out to Kyte creditors.

Kyte fell behind on some of its loans earlier this year, according to the notice. That caused the company's top lender to repossess and liquidate Kyte's vehicle fleet.

Kyte's board of directors “pursued various capital solutions” to keep the company alive, the notice states. But the company wasn't able to line up financing and the board voted to wind down Kyte.

While Kyte passed its customer list to Turo, a number of [users](#) who had prebooked trips before the shutdown have complained that they're stuck waiting on refunds for hundreds of dollars.

Some who spoke to TechCrunch said they were able to get their credit card companies to perform a charge-back, while others have had no luck. Kyte CEO Nikolaus Volk told TechCrunch in a message that charge-backs may be the quickest way for customers to get that money back.

Founded in 2019, Kyte provided on-demand rental cars that it also delivered directly to customers' homes. It controlled its own fleet of vehicles, making it a bit more like Zipcar and less like the peer-to-peer offerings of players like Turo. Kyte grew to 14 markets and raised more than \$300 million in financing over its lifetime, and started billing itself as the “best competitor to Hertz.”

The business started coming apart in 2024, Volk told TechCrunch last year. Kyte was struggling to generate free cash flow in markets like Atlanta, Chicago, Boston, and Washington, D.C. Volk said his team explored selling the business but decided to restructure and focus on

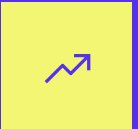
TC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- [HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach](#)
- [How your solar rooftop became a national security issue](#)
- [A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs](#)
- [Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company](#)
- [Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request](#)
- [NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars](#)



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Kyte's not the only startup in this sector to run into trouble — especially in the United States. Getaround, another peer-to-peer vehicle rental service, shuttered its U.S. operations [in February of this year](#) to focus on its European business. TrueCar founder Scott Painter [pivoted away from vehicle subscriptions](#) in 2024 after struggling to build up a business called Autonomy.

Topics: [Exclusive](#) [Kyte](#) [Transportation](#) [turo](#) [Zipcar](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)

Sean O'Kane

Sr. Reporter, Transportation | [X](#)

Sean O'Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the transportation industry, including Tesla and the ma...

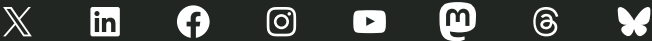
[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article



YOU HAVE ONLY 2 MOVES

IQ: 155



TechCrunch
Staff
Contact Us
Advertise
Crunchboard
Jobs
Site Map

Terms of Service
Privacy Policy
RSS Terms of Use

Neuralink
Google Chrome
StubHub
Claude
GPT-5
Tech Layoffs
ChatGPT